

Thursday, February 4, 2016 - 14:50 [Samsara](#)



Bradley Storer

What: Trickster

Where: The Butterfly Club

When: 2-7 February

Written by: Bradley Storer

Directed by : Emma Claire Ford

Performed by: Trevor Jones and Bradley Storer

Bradley Storer brings his new black cabaret *Trickster* to the Butterfly Club this week and you really should pop in and see it. The cabaret itself is clever and unexpected, and Storer is a uniquely talented and charismatic performer – I was thinking he seemed like some sort of Peter Allen/Jerry Lewis reincarnation.

Entering from the rear of the audience with a pallid complexion and all but naked, his eyes seemed demonically red as he stared deep into our souls throughout the performance. It was more than him just staring – he was drilling past our facade right into the very essence (and perhaps ugliness) of who we are as he took us through the journey of a humanity we tend to look away from.

Storer describes his tale as having a dash of darkness, a dollop of Weimar, a drop of Brecht and a morsel of post-modernism. I don't know about that last one, but the other three elements are there in delicious spadefuls.

Although the Weimar Republic was a political and economic catastrophe, one of the side effects was a thriving culture which included the Bauhaus and a night life beyond extravagance. Because the value of the German currency was falling so rapidly, people were going out and spending everything they had each night before it lost value, which made the night clubs, cinemas and theatres places of rampant creativity. Think Brecht, Kandinsky, Goethe, Liszt, Schiller – Weimar was the European capital of culture.

In *Trickster* Storer embraces all of that creativity to form a picture of humanity's darker side and he does it

employing all of the wonderful ideas (although potentially opposed) to do so. As with Brechtian epic work, Storer tells us what he is doing and how it will be done from the very start. As with Bauhaus though, the whole is only truly revealed by the sum of its parts.

Cabaret lovers and those who don't usually attend this type of performance will all love this show. The choice of songs and their arrangement is truly inspiring, fun, and unpredictable. If you enjoyed Arena Theatre's *Cautionary Tales for Children* or are a fan of the *Struwwelpeter* or *Sweeney Todd* aesthetic, *Trickster* will be right up your alley.

Brilliantly accompanied by Trevor Jones on the piano, Storer makes his way from Kate Bush's 'Babooshka' to Nick Cave's 'People Ain't No Good', going through dark alleys and crazy twists and turns along the way. My favourite song was 'Missed Me' and I don't think you will ever hear a more compelling rendition – not even the Dresden Dolls did it this well! Kurt Weill pops his head in too with 'Pirate Jenny'.

As good as the show and song choices are though, the reason *Trickster* works is because Storer is an absolutely genius performer. He grabbed us (metaphorically mostly...) from the very first moment and refused to let us go until he had finished with us and was ready to toss us away. He is a natural born storyteller with a truly fabulous voice which could just as easily fill arenas as is did the Butterfly Club.

One thing I was very impressed with was that Storer is a performer who actually knows how and when to use a microphone! I can't tell you how excited I was by this simple demonstration of skill or how amazing the correct use made his performance. Storer knew his instrument (the voice), what it could and couldn't do, and what the microphone was there – or not there as required – to do.

I guess you have figured out by now that I really enjoyed this show. It was musically fantastic, intellectually tickling, and full of fun and the unexpected. Yes, it is a bit dark, so let your evil side out to have a laugh when you come and see *Trickster*.

4.5 Stars.

---